The art of being sober in an age of gluttony



16.06.26 | BRICE LE ROUX

Welcome to the stuffOpsVerse

#ComplianceOps

#PlatformOps

#devSecOps

#MlOps

#finOps

#greenOps

#revOps

#policyOps

#devOps

#cloudOps

#complianceOps

#AIOps

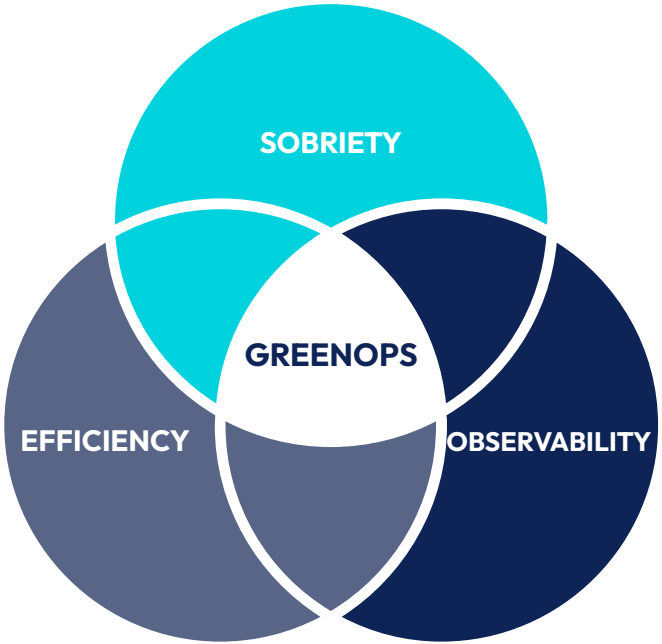
#gitOps

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What would greenOps be then ?

Sobriety

Reducing the environmental impact of digital systems by **deliberately constraining** usage, infrastructure, and data growth.



Efficiency

Doing more with less.

Engineering systems that **maximize the value** extracted from available resources.

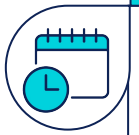
Observability

Measuring what matters and using observability data in a sustainable and intentional way.

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Efficiency : we're doing good, thank you.

Moore 01



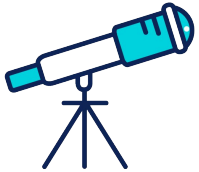
- **1965** : "The complexity of entry-level semiconductor devices doubles every year."
- **1975**: "The number of transistors on a silicon microprocessor chip doubles every two years."

From Moore's Law to erooM Law

erooM 02



- Software efficiency improves by a factor of two every two years.
- Goal: enable the creation of new uses and capabilities without requiring hardware improvements (new devices, datacenters, etc.).



What began as an empirical observation gradually became a planning rule for manufacturers, progressively distancing engineers from their original culture of frugality and efficiency.

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Observability : everything's on the table

From information to attention scarcity ?

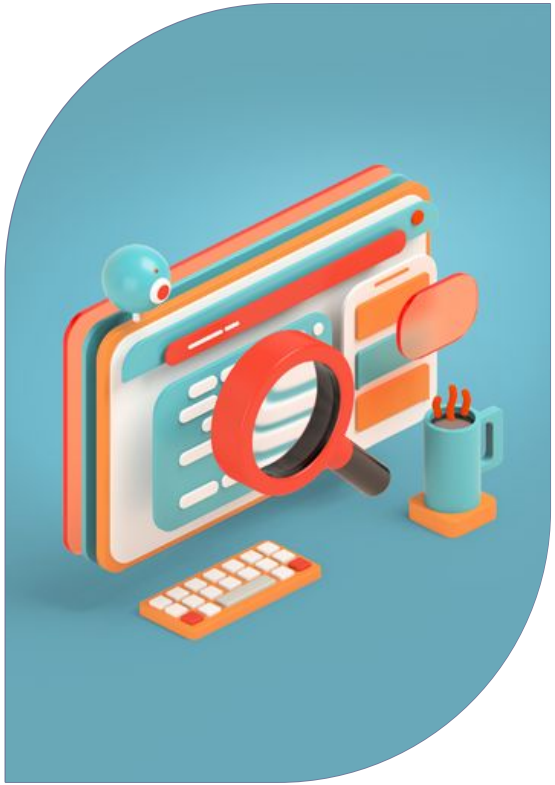
Observability followed the same pattern as computing itself.

As collecting telemetry became cheaper,

We collected more of it.

Then more.

Then much more.



We became extremely good at collecting signals.
The challenge is turning them into understanding.

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What happened to sobriety ?

Did we actually learn from Jevons ?

In *The Coal Question* (1865), Jevons observed that improvements in steam engine efficiency did not reduce coal consumption.

They made coal more economical to use.

As coal became cheaper, new uses emerged and overall consumption increased.

This became known as the **Jevons Paradox**.

Computing has been replaying the same story for fifty years.

Every gain in computing efficiency enabled more software, more infrastructure, more data and more telemetry.

Not less consumption. MORE consumption.



Improved energy efficiency → Lower cost of energy use → Higher energy consumption



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Scarcity doesn’t come naturally.

What sobriety making a come-back ?

2022-2023

Energy prices surged.

Cloud costs became impossible to ignore.

Inflation returned.

For the first time in years, digital organizations started asking uncomfortable questions:

- Do we really need this infrastructure?
- Do we really need this data?
- Do we really need this feature?

For a brief moment, constraints were back.



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Then came Generative AI

The conversation changed almost overnight.

The focus shifted from optimization to expansion.

From efficiency to capability.

From reducing consumption to increasing capacity.

Whas sobriety making a come-back ?

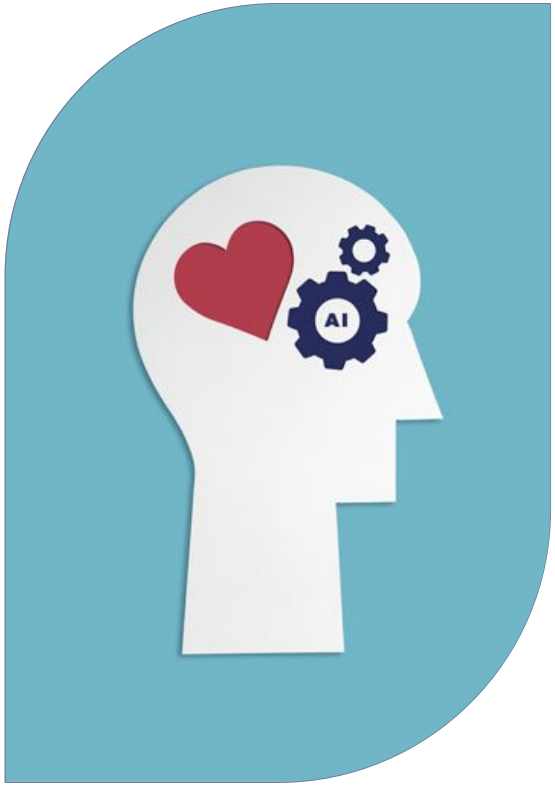
2024–2025

The race was on:

- More GPUs
- More datacenters
- More energy
- More investment
- More compute

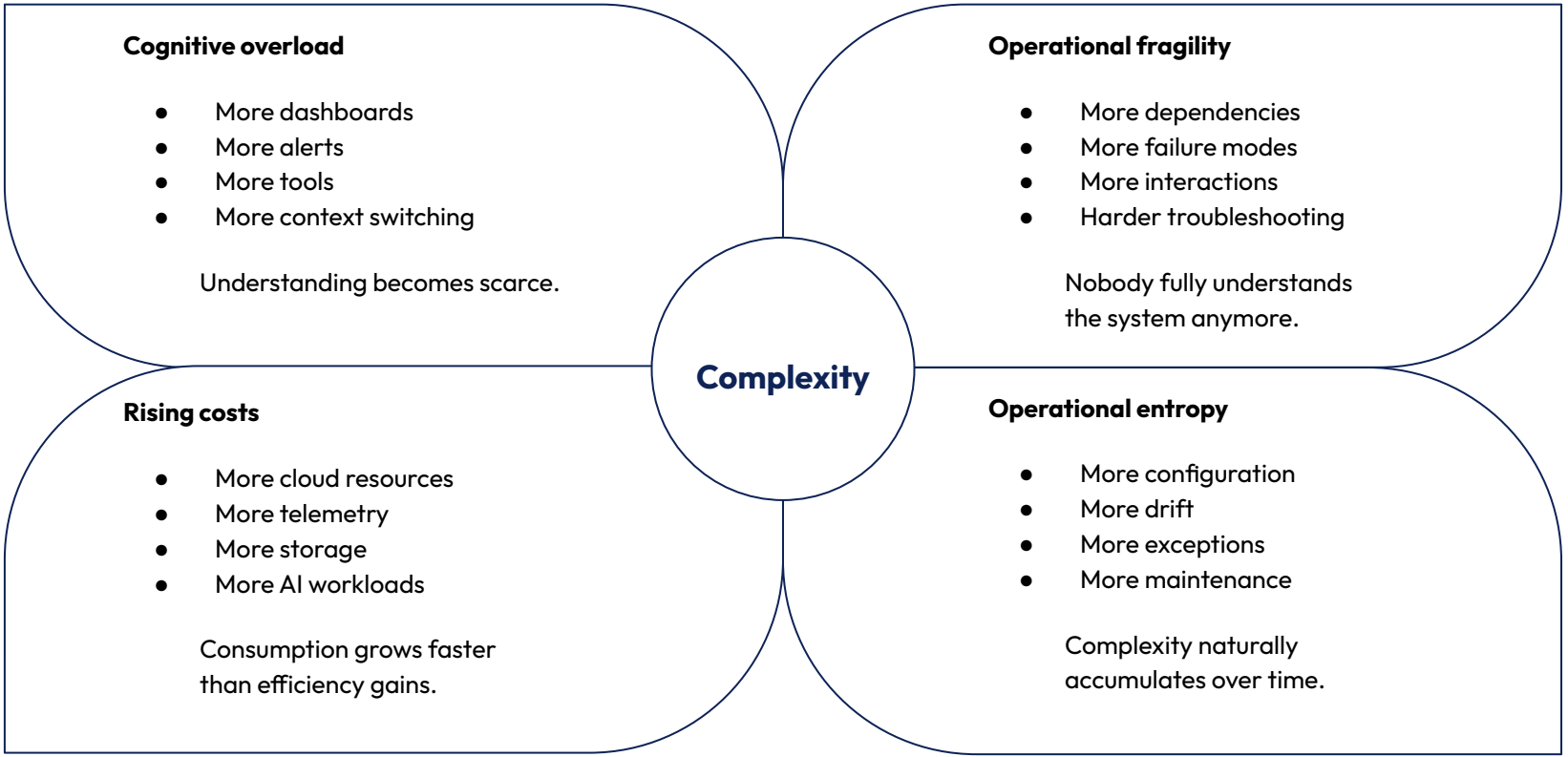
The narrative changed. Abundance was back.

We went from “Make planet greater again” to “plug baby plug”.



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Abundance came at a price



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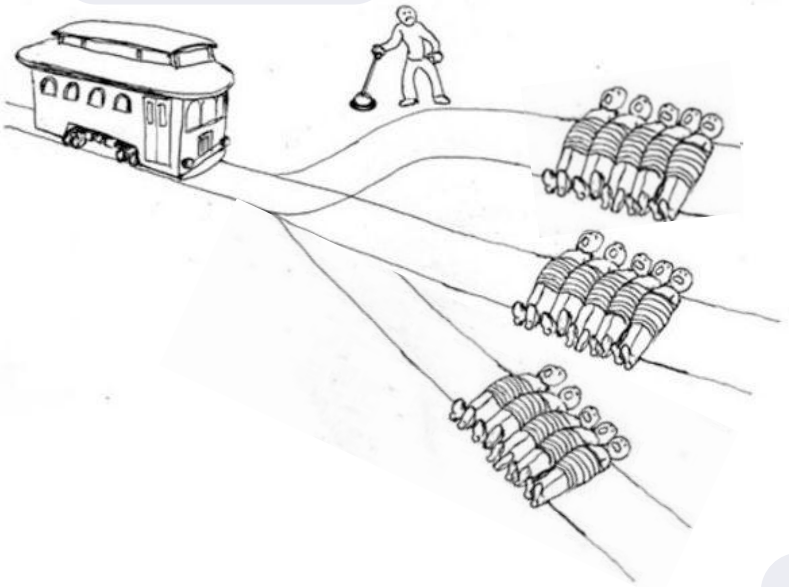
Everybody want to save the world... as long as it doesn't stand in the way of any other concern.

And they’re probably right.

Engineering is trade-offs

We, the engineers

Reality



Human factors

Cost

Reliability

Time-to-market

Security

Sustainability

Cost

Our jobs are essentially a continuous series of trade-offs.
(Or so we think)

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Convergence is better than trade-offs

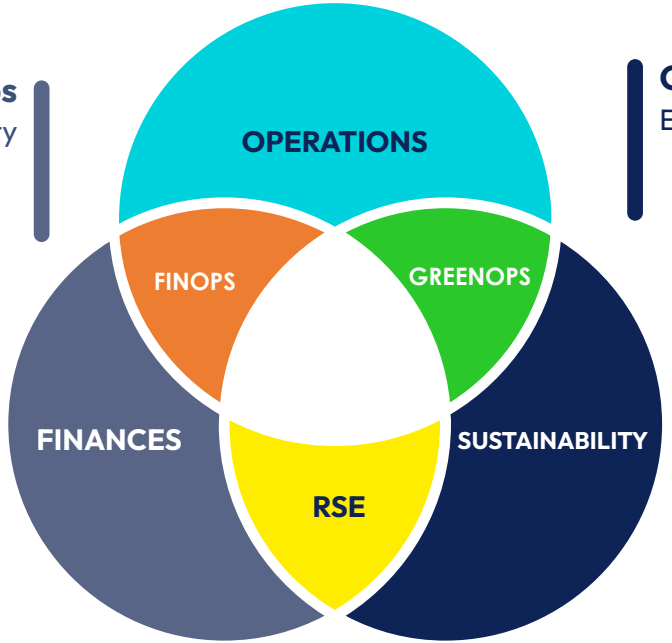
Initiative	Cost	Reliability	Sustainability	Human Load
Remove unused resources	✓	✓	✓	✓
Delete obsolete services	✓	✓	✓	✓
Reduce alert noise		✓		✓
Standardize logging	✓	✓	✓	✓
Improve observability		✓		✓
Simplify architecture	✓	✓	✓	✓
Reduce dependencies	✓	✓	✓	✓
Right-size workloads	✓	✓	✓	✓
Shorten data retention	✓	✓	✓	✓

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Different Vocabularies, Same Problem

Managing scarcity

FinOps
Financial scarcity



GreenOps
Environmental scarcity

RSE
Long-term resilience

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Scarcity doesn’t come naturally anymore

For most of engineering history, constraints were unavoidable.

- Limited compute
- Limited storage
- Limited bandwidth
- Limited energy
- Limited budgets

Today, most constraints are hidden behind layers of abstraction

- Cloud
- Autoscaling
- Managed Services
- On-demand GPUs
- GenAI

Which means we now need mechanisms to make constraints visible again.



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Carbon Budgets

Error Budgets

Data retention policies

Constraints are not failures.
Constraints are design tools

Rate limits

Guardrails

FinOps Budgets

We spent fifty years removing constraints.

The next challenge is learning which ones are worth putting back.



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